

EAM310 · EAM DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM · SUMMER 2026

Study Guide

Diagnosis by Palpation & Inquiry — Week 7

Prof. Daniel Schrier, D.O.M., L.Ac.
Week 7 · Diagnosis by Palpation & Inquiry · Summer 2026

What This Is

The complete Week 7 reference for both Diagnosis by Palpation and Diagnosis by Inquiry — channel and abdominal palpation methods first, then the full 16-Questions inquiry framework, organized question by question with pattern-correlation tables throughout.

The Things That Matter Most

If you retain nothing else: **1.** The three palpation techniques — Palpation (tracing), Pressing, Feeling. **2.** Tenderness/pain = excess; weak/soft = qi stagnation. **3.** The Nan Jing 5-phase abdominal map (Heart/Fire above navel, Spleen/Earth at navel, Kidney/Water below, Lung/Metal right, Liver/Wood left). **4.** Questions should confirm or exclude a pattern — never ask the 16 questions as a rote script. **5.** Pain has three classical mechanisms: impeded circulation, tension, lack of nourishment. **6.** Full vs. Empty logic runs through every question — aggravated by pressure/food/movement = Full; alleviated = Empty. **7.** The Neijing dream material is explicitly marked not tested.

PART I · Diagnosis by Palpation

Palpation is the fourth of the Four Pillars and the only one that gives you direct tactile evidence — of the channels, the skin, the hands and feet, the abdomen, and diagnostic points. It confirms or challenges everything Looking, Listening/Smelling, and Inquiry have already suggested.

What Palpation Can Tell Us

Information about the meridians and acu-points; the patient's overall condition and the general state of the meridians and organs; local or generalized stagnation; and Ashi/trigger points.

1 Channel Palpation in the Classics

Tracing the pathways of the 12 primary channels to assess the quality of qi and blood flow is discussed across the classical literature — Su Wen 20, Ling Shu 20/51/73/75, Zhang Zhongjing's *Shang Han Lun*, Sun Simiao's *Qian Jin Yao Fang*, and Li Shizhen's *Qijing Ba Mai Kao*.

Quiz Targets

Three techniques (Palpation/Pressing/Feeling) · direction of channel palpation (hands/feet → elbows/knees) · the three-pass pressing rule · tenderness = excess logic.

2 Three Techniques in Palpating the Channels

Technique	Method	What It Reveals
Palpation (tracing)	Running the fingers along the course of a channel, often from the hands/feet proximally toward the elbows/knees; done with the whole hand, not just the fingertips.	Structural changes along the channel – changes in muscle tension, nodules, bumpiness.
Pressing	Thumb or fingertip pressure to check for tenderness along a channel or at particular points; press three times, a bit harder each time, to feel for deeper changes.	Tenderness/pain = excess condition; more pain = accumulation of xie qi (pathogenic qi); weak/soft feeling (with or without tenderness) = qi stagnation; slippery and/or hard = phlegm.
Feeling	Discerning noticeable changes in temperature, moisture, and skin texture, and noting when an area feels different compared with others (not necessarily along the channels).	Baseline for the temperature/moisture/texture findings below.

Key nuance: *some structural changes are clear at the surface but disappear with deeper pressure, and vice versa – always palpate at more than one depth.*

3 Palpating the Skin – Temperature

Finding	Pattern
Cold feeling	Cold pattern
Four limbs cold	Spleen and Stomach Yang deficiency
Loins, lower back or feet cold	Kidney–Yang deficiency
Lower abdomen cold	Spleen–Yang deficiency
Skin hot	Heat or Damp–Heat
Skin hot on first touch, cools with sustained pressure	Exterior invasion of Wind–Heat – pathogenic factor still only on the Exterior
Skin over a blood vessel hot on medium pressure, not on heavy pressure	Interior Heat in the Middle Burner (Stomach) or the Heart
Skin hot on heavy pressure, nearly reaching the bone	Empty–Heat from Yin deficiency

4 Moisture & Texture

Finding	Pattern
Moist skin	Invasion of exterior Wind
Moist, no exterior symptoms	Lung-Qi deficiency
Dry skin	Blood deficiency or Yin deficiency
Rough skin	Bi Zheng/Painful Obstruction from Wind, or dryness of Liver-Blood
Swollen skin, pitting	"Water swelling" — Spleen and/or Kidney-Yang deficiency
Swollen skin, non-pitting	"Qi swelling" — Dampness or Qi stagnation

5 Palpation of Hands & Feet

Finding	Pattern
Cold hands and feet	Kidney-Yang deficiency or Liver-Qi stagnation
Cold hands	Lung and/or Heart Yang deficiency
Cold feet	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Cold hands and feet in women	Blood deficiency
Cold hands in women	Heart-Blood deficiency
Cold feet in women	Liver-Blood deficiency
Cold fingers/toes	Liver-Qi stagnation

6 Dorsal Surface vs. Palm

Ling Shu 74 discusses comparing the back (dorsal) of the hand with the palm.

Finding	Pattern
Hot dorsal surface	Full Heat conditions
Hot palm	Empty Heat conditions

7 Palpating the Hand — Reflex Zones

The palm reflects the state of most internal organs in a pattern similar to that found in the ear. Diagnosis is made by gently pressing the relevant reflex areas.

Finding on Pressure	Meaning
Sharp pain	Full condition
Dull soreness	Empty condition

8 Master Tung Palm Diagnosis

Palm diagnosis (zhang zhen) was one of Master Tung's core diagnostic tools. Ling Shu 10 is cited as an early source describing the vessels in the ball of the hand: greenish-blue suggests cold in the stomach, redness at the borderline suggests heat, sudden blackness points to a long-standing blockage, a mix of red/black/greenish-blue suggests combined cold and heat, and greenish-blue over only a short distance suggests diminished qi (Unschuld trans.). Also discussed in the *Zhen Jiu Jia Yi Jing*.

Mapping (finger → forearm point → organ)

Index finger → LU 10 = Lung · Middle finger → PC 8 = Heart · Ring finger → wrist = Liver & Spleen.

Palm Sign	Meaning
Examine palm for blood vessels, abnormal spots, tenderness	General diagnostic scan
Valvate (soft, atrophied) palm	Deficiency
Firm, tender palm	Excess
Warm	Heat
Cold	Cold

Skin Color	Meaning
Blue or black	Pain
Light blue	Cold and deficiency
Dark blue	Pain and excess
Red	Heat
Yellow and atrophy	Deficiency
Blue, red, black (mixed)	Mixed Heat and Cold
Very dark, gloomy color	Pathogen has invaded to the Interior
Pale color	Pathogen is still Exterior

9 Xu Li — the Apical Beat / “Interior Emptiness”

The apical impulse (Xu Li 虛里), described in Su Wen 18, reflects the state of Gathering Qi/Zong Qi.

Finding	Pattern
Clearly felt, not hard, relatively slow	Normal / healthy
Feeble and without strength	Deficiency of Zong Qi
Strong and hard	Excess condition of the Lungs and/or Heart
Large but empty	Heart-Qi deficiency
Stopping and starting	Severe shock or alcoholism — poor prognosis
Rapid	Shock, fright, or outburst of anger

10 Palpating the Area Below the Xiphoid Process

Reflects the state of Upper Burner Qi (Lung and Heart Qi). Normally it should feel soft, relative to the rest of the abdomen.

Finding	Pattern
Hard on palpation	Full condition; Qi stagnation (often from emotional problems)
Too soft on palpation	Heart deficiency

11 Palpating the Chest & Breast

Finding	Pattern
Tender with light palpation of CV 17	Heart–Blood stasis
Tender around the center of the chest	Lungs excess condition
Tenderness relieved by palpation	Heart or Lungs deficiency condition
Tenderness relieved by light palpation but elicited by deeper palpation	Combination of Deficiency and Excess

Breast Lump Palpation

Performed when there are breast lumps — this is never a replacement for Western diagnosis, only a way to identify the pattern behind the lump. Assess hardness, edges, and mobility.

Finding	Pattern
Relatively hard	Blood stasis, or Cold
Distinct edges	Phlegm
Indistinct edges	Toxic Heat
Mobile on palpation	Phlegm, Dampness
Immovable on palpation	Blood stasis or Toxic Heat

12 Abdominal Diagnosis — the Nan Jing 5-Phase Map

Discussed in the Nan Jing and later the *Shang Han Lun*: practitioners palpate five regions of the abdomen and, by discerning sensitivity at each, infer the balance of the associated organ. Japanese physicians (below) further evolved this into distinct diagnostic systems.

Region	Organ/Phase
Ren 12–15 (upper, around the sternum/epigastrium)	Heart / Fire
Around the umbilicus	Spleen / Earth
Ren 7–Pubis (below umbilicus)	Kidney / Water
Right side, below the rib cage	Lung / Metal
Left side, below the rib cage	Liver / Wood

Source: Matsuo Bicho (1868), *Hara Diagnosis: Reflections of the Sea*. Cite this map to the Nan Jing, per standing sourcing rules for pulse/organ-position content.

13 Japanese Abdominal Diagnosis — Fuku Shin

Figure	Contribution
Waichi Sugiyama (1610–1694)	Credited with developing abdominal palpation methods used widely in Japan; contributed further to abdominal diagnosis generally.
Todo Yoshimasu (1702–1773)	Developed diagnostic indicators by gently palpating the abdomen and associating findings with traditional formulas.
Inaba Bunrei & Yoshitora Wakuda (Shukuko)	Furthered the development of Fuku Shin into the 19th century.

Finding	Pattern
Normal	Feels solid but not hard, resilient but not tight, elastic but not soft
Hard and/or pain aggravated by palpation	Full condition
Too soft and/or ache relieved by palpation	Empty condition
Lower abdomen soft and flabby	Deficiency of Original Qi (Yuan Qi)
Fixed abdominal masses	Blood stasis

14 Palpating Points — Front-Mu & Back-Shu

Points can be used diagnostically following the same general principles outlined above for the channels; Back-Shu, Front-Mu, Lower He-Sea, and Ah Shi points are especially useful.

Point Category	Location & Significance
Front-Mu (募)	On the front (yin) surface of the body; the character signifies that these points tend to become sensitive to pressure as qi collects/accumulates in them — giving deep access to the yin aspect of each Organ's functioning.
Back-Shu (俞/膂)	On the back; Shu can be translated as “transport”/“transmission” points along the Bladder channel; particularly strong for evaluating and treating (tonification/sedation) the associated organ. Note the Shu points are located roughly level with their respective organs.

15 Aggressive Energy (AE) Treatment

A 5-Element (Worsley) treatment block created by “toxic” qi circulating in the Ke (control) cycle between the yin organs; hinted at in Su Wen Chapter 65. Usually stems from an internal cause — family/relationship problems, financial worries, work issues — though it can arise from external causes and shocks as well.

Points Used

BL 13, BL 14, BL 15, BL 18, BL 20, BL 23.

16 Palpating the Three Jiao

Jiao	Location	Contains
Upper Jiao	Chest, above the diaphragm	Heart, Pericardium, Lung
Middle Jiao	Between the xiphoid and the navel	Stomach, Spleen, Liver, Gall Bladder
Lower Jiao	Below the navel	Small & Large Intestine, Bladder, Kidney

Assessed visually and by touch to: assess the warmth and strength of the qi in each Jiao; determine whether moxibustion or warming should be a significant part of treatment; assess the progress of treatment; and assess how the patient reacts to physical contact.

PART II · Diagnosis by Inquiry

“Different disease, similar treatment. Similar disease, different treatment” — yī bìng tóng zhì, tóng bìng yì zhì 異病同治，同病異治.

Overview — General vs. Specific Questions

Category	Purpose
General Questions	Lifestyle, work, and habits — help paint an overall picture of the patient and disease.
Specific Questions	About clinical manifestations, to determine the pattern(s) of disharmony.

The Nature of “Symptoms” in Chinese Medicine

Signs and symptoms reflect the condition of the Zang-Fu/Internal Organs and Channels. Different manifestations are treated as parts of one whole picture, using the signs, symptoms, and other clinical findings to build a complete picture of the disharmony.

Asking the Right Questions

Principle	Detail
Questions should confirm or exclude a pattern	Every question should be purposeful, not just a rote script.
Don't follow the traditional 10/16 questions blindly	Always ask yourself <i>why</i> you are asking a particular question.

Problems with Terminology

Words used in TCM don't necessarily match what the patient will say. Example: "distending pain" is not the same as "bloated." Common symptom language will lead you toward possible causes — e.g. "I'm thirsty but have no desire to drink" can be a clue toward Damp-Heat.

Procedures for Interrogation/Inquiry

- Observe the patient as they enter the room and during the consultation (movement, complexion, eyes).
- Ask about the chief complaint/reason for treatment.
- Ask specific questions to determine the pattern(s) causing the presenting problem(s), trying to establish time of onset accurately.
- Ask follow-up questions to confirm or exclude other patterns; listen to tone of voice.
- Ask broader questions following the 16 questions — broadly, not rigidly.
- While establishing the cause of disease, ask about: past diseases/operations and family illnesses; social life — emotional life, family life, work conditions; normal hours (bed/wake); look at the tongue and feel the pulse.

Identification of Patterns

Once the chief complaint is described, begin organizing presenting symptoms/signs into patterns. While asking questions, continue observing complexion, eyes, facial shape, voice, and smells. Even once confident in a diagnosis, keep asking questions to exclude or confirm any other patterns that may stem from the primary one.

10 Traditional Questions (Maciocia) vs. Today's 16 Questions

Maciocia's 10 Questions

- 1. Chills and fever
- 2. Sweating
- 3. Head and body
- 4. Two excretions (stools & urine)
- 5. Diet (food and drink)
- 6. Chest and abdomen
- 7. Hearing
- 8. Thirst and drink (Qi and Flavor)
- 9. Previous illness (Yin/Yang based on pulse)
- 10. Cause of previous disease

Today's 16 Questions (Schrier)

- 1. Pain
- 2. Food and Taste
- 3. Stools and Urine
- 4. Thirst and Drink
- 5. Energy Level
- 6. Head, Face and Body
- 7. Chest and Abdomen
- 8. Limbs
- 9. Sleep
- 10. Sweating
- 11. Ears and Eyes
- 12. Feeling of Cold, Feeling of Heat and Fever
- 13. Emotional Symptoms
- 14. Sexual Symptoms
- 15. Women's Symptoms
- 16. Children's Symptoms

The “newly added” questions relative to the classic 10 are: Pain, Emotions, Sexual Life/Symptoms, and “Energy” Level.

Question 1 — Pain

The Huang Di Neijing devotes many chapters to pain syndromes — key chapters are Su Wen 39 and 43, and Ling Shu 27 and 53. Per the Neijing, pain arises from three main mechanisms.

Mechanism	Classical Source & Logic
1. Circulation is impeded	Su Wen 39: when cold qi enters the conduits, stoppage and retardation result — the vessel contents fail to flow, causing sudden pain. Su Wen 39 (pressure variant): when cold qi settles inside the conduits and strikes against heat qi there, the vessels become full and cannot be pressed; when cold stagnates and heat qi follows it upward, the vessels become full and big and qi/blood fall into disorder — pain is extreme and unpressable.
2. Tension	Su Wen 39: cold qi outside the vessels makes them cold, and cold vessels shrink and curve, pulling on the small network vessels outside — producing sudden pain. When cold settles in the region of the intestines/stomach and blood cannot disperse, the small network vessels become tense and pull, causing pain; pressing the location disperses blood/qi and ends the pain (Ling Shu 10, Su Wen 62, Su Wen 39 — heat also dissolves cold-based tension).
3. Lack of nourishment	The channels/vessels moisten the sinews and bones and keep joints flexible; when the vessels are impeded the blood becomes depleted, and depleted blood produces pain. Diminished qi and blood also predispose to cramping pain.

Palpation Cross-Reference

Relieved with pressure = cold qi guests between the Stomach and Intestines, dispersing blood and qi upon compression. Palpation doesn't help = cold qi is deep-lying along the spine and cannot be reached by compression.

Pain — Etiology, Full vs. Empty

Category	Causes			
Full conditions	Invasion of exterior pathogenic factors · interior Cold/Heat · stagnation of Qi or Blood · obstruction			
Empty conditions	Deficiency of Qi, Blood, Yang, or Yin · consumption of body fluids from Yin deficiency			

Factor	Empty	Full	Cold	Heat
Character	Dull	Sharp	Cramping	Burning
Temperature	—	—	Alleviated by heat	Alleviated by cold
Food	Alleviated	Aggravated	—	—
Bowel movement	Alleviated	Aggravated	—	—
Pressure	Better lying down	Better sitting up	—	—
Vomiting	Alleviated	Aggravated	—	—
Rest/movement	Better with rest	Better with movement	Better with movement	Worse with movement

Table 24.1 (Maciocia), Factors Affecting Pain — cite to FCM, not reconstructed from memory if you have the chapter PDF available.

Causes of Pain by Character

Pain Character	Pattern
Distending, throbbing, coming and going	Qi stagnation
Chronic, distending, throbbing	Liver–Yang rising
Severe, boring or stabbing, fixed location	Blood stasis
Cramping, aggravated by cold, better with warmth	Cold
Burning, with a feeling of fullness	Heat
Aggravated by damp weather	Damp–Heat
Headache and stiffness	External Wind
Pain in the joints	External Dampness
Intense pain with a feeling of fullness	Retention of food
Pain (uncommon, but can occur, esp. joints as in RA)	Phlegm

Origin	Typical Organs/Structures	Typical Locations
Blood stasis	Uterus, Heart, Stomach, Intestines	Head, chest, epigastrium, abdomen, uterus
Interior Cold	Stomach, Uterus, Intestines	Epigastrium, uterus, abdomen, joints
Damp–Heat	Stomach, Uterus, Intestines, Bladder, Gall Bladder	Hypochondrium, epigastrium, abdomen, hypogastrium, joints
External Wind	None specific	Head, joints
External Dampness	Stomach, Intestines, Uterus	Head, epigastrium, abdomen, uterus, joints
Phlegm	Stomach, Intestines, Uterus	Head, epigastrium, abdomen, joints

Table 24.2 (Maciocia), *Causes of Pain and Location*.

Bi Syndrome Pain (by pathogen)

Type	Presentation	Pathogen
Wandering (行痺)	Pain moves from joint to joint	Wind
Painful (痛痺)	Severe, fixed pain	Cold
Fixed (著痺)	Soreness and heaviness	Damp
Heat (熱痺)	Sudden onset, swelling and redness	Heat
Bone (骨痺, chronic)	Pain, swelling, joint deformity – a chronic/interior progression of the four types above	Chronic combined pathogen

Pain — Food & Eating Relationship

Finding	Pattern
Condition relieved by eating	Empty condition
Condition aggravated by eating	Full condition

Question 2 — Food and Taste

Appetite & Fullness

Finding	Pattern
Lack of appetite	Spleen-Qi deficiency
Excessive hunger	Stomach-Heat
Feeling of fullness	Dampness or retention of food
Feeling of distention	Qi stagnation

Taste

Taste	Pattern
Lack of taste sensation	Spleen and Stomach deficiency
Bitter taste	Heat in the Liver or Heart
Sweet taste	Spleen deficiency or Damp-Heat
Sour taste	Retention of food, or Liver invading Stomach
Salty taste	Kidney-Yin deficiency
Pungent taste	Lung-Heat

Bitter taste timing: Heart pattern = worse in the morning after poor sleep; Liver pattern = constant through the day.

Vomiting

Vomit / Pattern	Meaning
Sour	Liver invading the Stomach
Bitter	Liver and/or Gall Bladder-Heat
Clear, watery	Cold in the Stomach
Soon after eating	Heat in the Stomach
Sudden, with a loud noise	Full condition
Slow in coming, with a weak noise	Empty condition

Question 3 — Stools and Urine

Stools — Constipation

Finding	Pattern
Better after a bowel movement	Full condition
Constipation with thirst and dry yellow tongue coating	Heat in the Stomach and Intestines
Constipation in the elderly or postpartum women	Deficiency of Blood
Difficulty performing a bowel movement (stools not dry)	Stagnation of Liver-Qi
Constipation with abdominal pain	Interior Cold (Full or Empty)
Thirst with small sips, difficulty passing stools	Yin deficiency (usually Kidneys and/or Stomach)
Deficiency of Central Qi with sinking of Spleen-Qi	Difficulty expelling despite soft stools
Alternating constipation and diarrhea	Stagnant Liver-Qi invading the Spleen

Stools — Diarrhea

Finding	Pattern
Chronic loose stools/diarrhea	Spleen and/or Kidney-Yang deficiency
Chronic diarrhea every day, very early morning	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Diarrhea with abdominal pain	Interior Cold in the Intestines
Diarrhea with mucus	Dampness in the Intestines
Diarrhea with blood and mucus	Damp-Heat in the Intestines
Loose stools with undigested food	Spleen-Qi deficiency
Black or very dark stools	Blood stasis
Blood first, bright red, splashing	Heat in the Blood; Damp-Heat in the Intestines
Blood first, turbid, heavy/painful anus	Damp-Heat in the Intestines
Stools first, then watery blood	Spleen-Qi deficient, unable to hold Blood
Pain accompanying diarrhea	Liver involvement, or Heat

Finding	Pattern
Foul-smelling stools	Heat
Absence of smell	Cold
Borborygmus with loose stools	Spleen deficiency
Borborygmus with distention, no loose stools	Stagnation of Liver-Qi
Flatulence, foul smell	Damp-Heat in the Spleen, or Heat
Flatulence without smell	Interior Cold from Spleen-Yang deficiency
Burning sensation in the anus while passing stools	Heat

Urine

Aspect	Finding	Pattern
Function	Enuresis or incontinence	Kidney deficiency
	Retention of urine	Dampness in the Bladder; occasionally Lung-Qi deficiency
	Difficulty urinating	Dampness in the Bladder, or Kidney deficiency (more common in the elderly)
Pain	Before urination	Qi stagnation in the Lower Burner
	During urination	Damp-Heat in the Bladder
	After urination	Qi deficiency
Color	Pale (clear)	Cold
	Dark	Heat
	Turbid/cloudy	Dampness
	Clear at start of exterior illness, not yet dark	Pathogenic factor has not penetrated to the Interior
Amount	Very frequent and copious	Kidney-Yang deficiency
	Frequent and scanty	Qi deficiency
	Scanty and dark	Kidney-Yin deficiency

Question 4 — Drink and Thirst

Finding	Pattern
Desire to drink cold liquids	Heat
Desire to drink warm liquids	Cold
Thirst with desire for large amounts of cold liquid	Full Heat
Absence of thirst	Cold, or no Heat present
Thirst but no desire to drink (or small sips)	Damp-Heat, or Yin deficiency

Question 5 — Energy Level (Tiredness)

Presentation	Pattern
Tiredness, worse in the morning	Spleen-Qi or Spleen-Yang deficiency
Chronic tiredness, weak voice	Lung-Qi or Lung-Yang deficiency
Chronic tiredness, feeling cold	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Chronic tiredness, dizziness, blurred vision, scanty periods	Liver-Blood deficiency
Chronic tiredness, dizziness, five-palm heat, no tongue coating	Kidney-Yin deficiency
Chronic tiredness, feeling of heaviness	Dampness
Chronic tiredness, muzy-headedness, dizziness	Phlegm
Chronic tiredness, abdominal distention, irritability, Wiry pulse	Liver-Qi stagnation
Alternating tired/energetic, hot/cold feeling, irritability, alternating bitter taste, Wiry pulse	Lesser Yang (Shao Yang) pattern

Question 6 — Head, Face, and Body

Headache — Onset & Time of Day

Finding	Pattern
Recent onset, short duration	Exterior attack of Wind-Cold
Gradual onset, in attacks	Interior type
Worse in the daytime	Qi or Yang deficiency
Worse in the evening	Blood or Yin deficiency
Worse at night-time	Blood stasis

Headache — Location (Channel)

Location	Channel & Typical Cause
Nape of neck	Tai Yang channels — exterior invasion of Wind-Cold, or interior Kidney deficiency
Forehead	Yang Ming channels — Stomach-Heat, or Blood deficiency
Temples and sides of head	Shao Yang channels — exterior Wind in Lesser Yang, or interior Liver/Gall Bladder Fire rising
Vertex	Jue Yin channels — usually deficiency of Liver-Blood
Whole head	Exterior invasion of Wind-Cold

Headache — Pain Quality

Quality	Pattern
Heavy feeling	Dampness or Phlegm
Painful, empty sensation inside the head, relieved by pressure	Kidney deficiency
Distending, throbbing	Rising of Liver-Yang
Boring, like a nail in a fixed point	Blood stasis
Muzziness and heaviness	Dampness
Muzziness, heaviness, and dizziness	Phlegm

Headache — Condition

Modifying Factor	Pattern
Aversion to wind or cold	Exterior invasion
Aggravated by cold	Cold pattern
Aggravated by heat	Heat pattern
Aggravated by fatigue, improved by rest	Qi deficiency
Aggravated by emotional tension	Liver–Yang rising
Aggravated by sexual activity	Kidney deficiency

Dizziness

Finding	Pattern
Severe giddiness, everything sways, loss of balance	Internal Wind, Liver–Yang rising
Accompanied by a feeling of heaviness	Phlegm
Slight, aggravated when tired	Blood deficiency
Sudden onset	Full pattern
Gradual onset	Empty pattern

Face — Facial Pain, Runny Nose

Finding	Pattern
Acute onset, severe pain of cheeks/jaws, hot feeling, hot on palpation	Invasion of Wind–Heat
Acute onset, spastic pain of cheeks/jaws, sneezing, aversion to cold, hot backs of hands, runny nose	Invasion of Wind–Cold
Thick, sticky–yellow discharge	Invasion of Wind–Heat, or Damp–Heat in the Stomach channel
Chronic runny nose, thin, watery discharge	Wind–Cold, or Lung–Qi deficiency with Cold
Chronic runny nose, thick sticky discharge, usually yellow	Damp–Heat in the Stomach channel

Face — Gums, Mouth Ulcers, Cold Sores

Finding	Pattern
Bleeding gums, tiredness, poor appetite, loose stools	Deficient Spleen-Qi not holding Blood
Inflamed, bleeding gums, feeling of heat, thirst	Stomach Full-Heat
Bleeding gums, dizziness, tinnitus, night sweating, malar flush	Kidney-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
Ulcers inside the cheeks	Stomach-Heat
Very painful, red-rimmed gum ulcers	Stomach Full-Heat
Pale-rimmed gum ulcers	Stomach Empty-Heat
Ulcers on the tip of the tongue	Heart-Fire or Heart Empty-Heat
Ulcers during pregnancy	Disharmony of the Ren Mai
Pale-rimmed ulcers, aggravated by overwork	Kidney-Yin deficiency or Original-Qi deficiency
Cold sores — sudden, burning pain	Stomach Heat
Cold sores — recurring over years	Stomach Empty-Heat
Cold sores — pale, aggravated by overwork	Qi deficiency

Cold sores generally relate to the Stomach channel, reflecting Full-Heat, Empty-Heat, or Qi deficiency depending on presentation.

Body — Generalized Pain, Back Pain, Numbness

Finding	Pattern
Sudden onset, aversion to cold and fever	Exterior Wind invasion
Ache all over, tiredness	Qi-Blood deficiency
Postpartum, dull pain	Blood deficiency
Postpartum, severe pain	Blood stasis
Pain in all muscles, hot feeling of the flesh	Stomach-Heat
Dull ache in the muscles (esp. limbs), heaviness	Dampness obstructing the muscles
Back pain, continuous, dull, better with rest	Kidney deficiency

Finding	Pattern
Back pain, recent onset, severe stabbing	Blood stasis
Back pain, worse in cold/damp weather, better with heat	Invasion of exterior Cold-Damp
Pain and stiffness of the neck and shoulders	Invasion of exterior Wind
Numbness of arms/legs or hands/feet, bilateral	Blood deficiency
Numbness of fingers/elbow/arm, one side (esp. first 3 fingers)	Internal Wind and Phlegm — possible impending Wind-stroke

Question 7 — Chest and Abdomen

Chest

Finding	Pattern
Stabbing chest pain	Heart-Blood stasis
Chest pain with cough and profuse yellow sputum	Phlegm-Heat in the Lungs
Feeling of oppression of the chest (Phlegm)	Phlegm obstructing the Lungs
Feeling of oppression of the chest (Qi stagnation)	Liver-Qi stagnation

Hypochondrium & Epigastrium

Finding	Pattern
Feeling of distention of the hypochondrium	Liver-Qi stagnation
Stabbing pain in the hypochondrium	Blood stasis
Dull epigastric pain, alleviated by eating	Empty/Deficiency condition
Severe epigastric pain, aggravated by eating	Full/Excess condition
Stabbing pain in the epigastrium	Heat in the Stomach; retention of food; Stomach or Phlegm Fire in the Stomach; Blood stasis in the Stomach; Liver-Qi invading the Stomach
Feeling of fullness/heaviness in the epigastrium	Dampness

Lower Abdomen & Hypogastrium

Finding	Pattern
Lower abdominal pain (general)	Internal Cold, Qi stagnation, Damp-Heat, or Blood stasis
Abdominal pain relieved by bowel movement	Full condition
Abdominal pain aggravated by bowel movement	Empty condition
Hypogastric pain	Damp-Heat in the Bladder

Question 8 — Limbs

Numbness, Tingling, Joint Pain

Finding	Pattern
Tingling sensation	Blood deficiency
Numbness, often unilateral	Wind, or Wind-Phlegm
Heaviness, aching, numbness in joints/limbs	Dampness
Numbness with pain	Qi or Blood stagnation

Joint Pain Character	Pattern
Migrates, worsens with wind exposure	Wind
Severe, fixed, worse with cold	Cold
Heavy aching, worse with humidity	Dampness
Redness, swelling, heaviness	Heat/Damp-Heat

Atrophy, Flaccidity, Tremor

Finding	Pattern
Atrophy/flaccidity, early stages	Stomach and Spleen-Qi deficiency
Atrophy/flaccidity, later stages	Deficiency of Liver & Kidney Yin, or Spleen & Kidney Yang
Tremor	Always indicates Liver-Wind (can be Excess or Deficiency type)

Cold Hands/Feet, Weak Knees

Finding	Pattern
Cold hands with palpitations, dizziness	Heart-Blood deficiency
Cold fingers/toes	Liver-Qi stagnation
Cold hands/feet in women	Liver-Blood deficiency
Weak knees	Kidney deficiency, especially Kidney-Yang

Heaviness & Lethargy

Finding	Pattern
Feeling of heaviness (general)	Dampness (can combine with Heat or Cold)
Heaviness in all four limbs (Spleen-Qi + Stomach-Qi deficiency together)	Combined Spleen-Qi/Stomach-Qi deficiency
Sleepy after eating	Spleen-Qi deficiency
General lethargy, heaviness of the body	Retention of Dampness
Extreme lethargy, lack of energy, feeling cold	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Lethargic stupor, rattling in the throat, slippery pulse, sticky coating	Phlegm misting the Mind

Question 9 — Sleep

Sleep depends on the state of Blood and Yin, especially of the Heart and Liver; the Spleen can also influence sleep. The Mind/Shen and Ethereal Soul/Hun must be anchored by sufficient Heart and Liver Blood for good sleep. Sleep need generally decreases across the lifespan — highest in babies, lowest in the elderly.

Finding	Pattern
Not falling or staying asleep	Deficiency of Blood not anchoring the Mind/Shen and/or Ethereal Soul/Hun (Empty condition)
Very restless sleep, heat, agitation, excessive dreaming	Pathogenic factors agitating the Mind/Shen and/or Hun out of Blood (Full condition)
Difficulty falling asleep	Blood deficiency (usually Heart, can be Liver or Spleen)
Insomnia, difficulty falling asleep, dizziness, blurred vision	Heart and Spleen Blood deficiency
Waking many times during the night	Yin deficiency with Empty Heat (Heart, Liver, or Kidneys)
Insomnia, frequent waking, excessive dreams, night sweating, palpitations	Heart and Kidney Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
Waking early, unable to fall back asleep	Gall Bladder deficiency
Dream-disturbed sleep	Liver-Fire or Heart-Fire
Restless sleep with excessive dreams	Retention of food

Not Tested

The “Categories of Dreams” and Neijing dream material (Su Wen 17/80, Ling Shu 43) presented as bonus/cultural context is explicitly marked **“will not be tested on”** in Schrier’s slides. It’s worth reading for context, but it is not quiz/exam scope.

Question 10 — Sweating

Category	Causes
Full conditions often due to	Heat · Damp-Heat
Empty conditions often due to	Deficiency of Yang · deficiency of Yin

Location/Quality/Timing	Pattern
Only on the head	Heat in the Stomach or Damp-Heat; (in severe illness) collapse of Yang
Only on arms and legs	Stomach and Spleen deficiency
Whole body	Lung-Qi deficiency
On palms, soles, and chest	Yin deficiency (five-palm heat)
In daytime (spontaneous sweating)	Yang deficiency
At night-time (night sweats)	Yin deficiency (occasionally Damp-Heat)
Profuse, cold sweat during severe illness	Collapse of Yang
Oily sweat on forehead, like pearls, not flowing	Collapse of Yang — danger of imminent death
Oily sweat quality (general)	Severe Yang deficiency
Yellow sweat	Damp-Heat

Question 11 — Ears and Eyes

Tinnitus & Deafness

Finding	Pattern
Sudden onset	Full condition — Liver-Fire, Liver-Yang rising, Liver-Wind
Gradual onset	Empty condition — Kidney deficiency (deafness: also Heart-Blood or Qi of the Upper Burner)
Noise aggravated by pressing on the ears	Full condition
Noise alleviated by pressing on the ears	Empty condition
Loud, high-pitched, whistle-like	Liver-Yang, Liver-Fire, Liver-Wind
Low-pitched, like rushing water	Kidney deficiency

Eyes

Finding	Pattern
Pain, swelling, redness	Invasion of Wind-Heat, or Liver-Fire
Feeling of pressure	Kidney-Yin deficiency
Blurred vision with floaters	Liver-Blood, Liver-Yin, or Kidney-Yin deficiency
Blurred vision with photophobia	Liver-Blood deficiency, or Liver-Yang rising
Dry eyes	Liver and/or Kidney-Yin deficiency

Question 12 — Feeling of Cold, Feeling of Heat, and Fever

Presentation	Interior/Exterior	Framework Correlation
Feeling of cold OR feeling of heat (not both)	Interior condition	—
Simultaneous aversion to cold and “fever”	Exterior condition — the key sign of an exterior pathogenic invasion	Wind-Cold at the Tai Yang stage (Six Stages); Wei/Defensive Level (Four Levels)
Alternating feeling of cold and heat	Exterior/Interior transitional	Shao Yang stage (Six Stages); Gall Bladder Heat in the Qi Level (Four Levels)

Aversion to Cold — Mechanism

Subjectively feeling cold, ranging from mild to strong, is due to invasion of Wind (Wind-Cold or Wind-Heat). Wind obstructs the Cou Li (space between skin and muscle) where Wei Qi circulates; when Wei Qi cannot warm the muscles, the patient feels cold.

Fever — Mechanism

“Fever” does not necessarily mean a raised temperature — it means the patient’s body feels hot on palpation. Its intensity reflects the struggle between Zheng Qi (Upright Qi) and the pathogenic factor, not which pathogen is involved: both strong → high fever; both weak → low fever; one strong/one weak → medium fever.

A feeling of heat with both subjective heat and objectively hot skin indicates the pathogenic factor has entered the Interior; this may or may not include an actual fever.

Feeling of Cold — by Location

Location	Pattern
Cold limbs and abdomen	Spleen-Yang/Stomach-Yang deficiency
Cold hands and feet, especially fingers	Liver-Qi stagnation
Cold hands and chest	Heart-Blood deficiency or Yang deficiency
Cold feet	Kidney-Yang deficiency, or Liver-Qi stagnation
Cold legs, knees, feet, back	Kidney-Yang deficiency

Feeling of Heat & Fever — by Timing

Timing	Pattern
Afternoon or evening	Empty-Heat
Low-grade, worse in the afternoon or only afternoon	Yin deficiency

Timing	Pattern
Constant low-grade temperature	Damp-Heat
Middle of the night	Yin deficiency

Question 13 — Emotional Symptoms

Emotions are among the Internal Causes of Disease and play a major role in the etiology and clinical picture of many complaints; the emotional state reflects the state of the Mind/Spirit.

Depression

Presentation	Pattern
Insomnia, palpitations, tiredness, weak limbs, loose stool	Spleen and Heart–Blood deficiency
Palpitations, cold hands	Heart–Yang deficiency
Lack of sense of direction, sadness	Liver–Blood deficiency
Anxiety, night sweating, palpitations, Red tongue without coating	Kidney and Heart–Yin deficiency with Empty–Heat
Moodiness, irritability	Liver–Qi stagnation
Irritability, Red tongue	Stagnant Liver–Qi turning into Heat
Moodiness, irritability, lump-in-throat sensation	Liver–Qi stagnation with Phlegm
Severe, manic behavior, mental confusion, Swollen tongue	Phlegm–Fire harassing the Mind

Anxiety

Presentation	Pattern
Insomnia, palpitations	Heart–Blood deficiency
Palpitations, timidity, Choppy/ Fine pulse, insomnia	Heart–Qi deficiency
Depression, insomnia, blurred vision	Liver–Blood deficiency
Depression, insomnia, no tongue coating	Liver–Yin deficiency
Worse in the evening, lack of will-power, dizziness, tinnitus	Kidney–Yin deficiency
Insomnia, palpitations, timidity	Heart and Gall Bladder Qi deficiency

Presentation	Pattern
Palpitations, mental restlessness, insomnia, dream-disturbed sleep, worse evening, poor memory, dizziness, tinnitus, low back ache, dry mouth/throat, five-palm heat, scanty dark urine	Kidney and Heart-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
Sweating, Red tongue without coating, redder tip with red points	Heart-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
Liver Qi Stagnation	Anxiety, depression, irritability, hypochondrial distention
Liver-Yang rising	Anxiety, headache (esp. temples), tinnitus, deafness, blurred vision, dizziness
Liver-Fire	Red eyes, thirst, bitter taste, dark-yellow urine, epistaxis, Full Wiry Rapid pulse
Phlegm-Fire harassing the Mind	Severe anxiety, palpitations, manic behavior, mental confusion, Swollen tongue

Irritability / Anger — Possible Root Patterns

- Qi stagnation
- Blood stasis
- Liver-Yang rising
- Blood deficiency
- Yin deficiency (with or without Empty-Heat)
- Heat (including Damp-Heat)

Worry / Overthinking

Presentation	Pattern
Slightly obsessive thinking, palpitations, slight depression, overthinking, loose stools, Pale tongue, Empty pulse	Heart and Spleen Qi deficiency
Cough, weak voice, Pale tongue, Empty pulse	Lung-Qi deficiency
Worry, depression, palpitations, Pale and Thin tongue, Choppy/Fine pulse	Heart-Blood deficiency
Worry increasing after menses, Pale tongue, blurred vision, Choppy/Fine pulse	Liver-Blood deficiency

Presentation	Pattern
Poor memory, anxiety, propensity to be startled, mental restlessness, "hot and bothered," redder tip, no coating	Heart-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat

Sadness and Grief

Presentation	Pattern
Crying, depression, palpitations, breathlessness, dislike of speaking, Pale tongue, Empty pulse	Lung and Heart-Qi deficiency
Crying, depression, blurred vision, aimlessness, Pale tongue, Choppy/Fine pulse	Liver-Blood deficiency
Crying, depression, palpitations, disturbed sleep, propensity to be startled, Pale and Thin tongue, Choppy/Fine pulse	Heart-Blood deficiency

Question 14 — Sexual Symptoms

Men

Presentation	Pattern
Impotence with feeling of cold, backache, abundant clear urine	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Impotence with dizziness, palpitations, Choppy pulse	Heart-Blood deficiency
Impotence, rapid overflowing pulse	Heart-Fire
Heaviness of the scrotum, urethral discharge, sticky-yellow coating	Damp-Heat in the Liver channel

Lack of Libido / Ejaculation Symptom	Possible Patterns
Lack of libido	Kidney-Yang or Qi deficiency · Kidney-Qi not Firm · Spleen deficiency · Heart-Qi deficiency
Premature ejaculation	Heart deficiency · Heart-Blood deficiency · Lung deficiency
Tiredness and dizziness after ejaculation	Liver-Qi stagnation · deficiency of the Kidneys

Women

Presentation	Pattern
Lack of libido, or inability to reach orgasm	Kidney or Heart deficiency, Kidney-Yang deficiency
Excessive sexual desire	Liver or Heart-Fire, or Empty-Heat from Kidney-Yin deficiency
Inability to reach orgasm	Heart deficiency
Headache after orgasm	Rebellious Qi of the Penetrating Vessel (Chong Mai), or Heart-Fire

Question 15 — Special Questions Regarding Women's Health

Menstruation — Cycle & Amount

Finding	Pattern
Periods always early	Blood-Heat, or Qi deficiency
Periods always late	Blood deficiency, or stagnation of Blood or Cold
Periods irregular (sometimes early, sometimes late)	Liver-Qi stagnation, or Spleen deficiency
Profuse periods	Blood-Heat, or Qi deficiency
Scanty periods	Blood deficiency, or stagnation of Blood or Cold

Menstruation — Color & Quality

Finding	Pattern
Pale or bright red	Blood-Heat
Pale	Blood deficiency
Purple or blackish, with clots	Stasis of Blood or Cold
Fresh red	Empty-Heat from Yin deficiency
Watery blood	Blood or Yin deficiency
Turbid blood	Blood-Heat, or stagnation of Cold

Menstrual Pain — Timing

Timing	Pattern
Before the period	Stagnation of Qi or Blood
During the period	Blood-Heat, or stagnation of Cold
After the period	Blood deficiency

Leukorrhea

Finding	Pattern
Greenish-yellow	Damp-Heat in the Liver channel
Yellow with pus and blood after menopause	Toxic Damp-Heat in the uterus

Finding	Pattern
Watery	Cold-Damp
Thick/sticky	Damp-Heat
Leathery	Damp-Heat

Pregnancy & Childbirth

Finding	Pattern
Infertility	Blood or Kidney-Essence deficiency; Damp-Phlegm in the Lower Burner; stasis of Blood in the Uterus; Cold in the Uterus
Vomiting during pregnancy	Stomach and Chong Vessel deficiency
Miscarriage before 3 months	Blood or Essence deficiency
Miscarriage after 3 months	Liver-Blood stasis, or sinking of Spleen-Qi
Nausea and heavy bleeding after delivery	Exhaustion of the Chong (Penetrating) Vessel
Sweating and fever after delivery	Exhaustion of Qi and Blood
Post-natal depression	Heart-Blood deficiency

Question 16 — Special Questions Regarding Children's Health

Digestive

Finding	Pattern
Abdominal pain	Cold in the Stomach and Intestines, or Qi stagnation
Vomiting of milk and colic in babies	Retention of food

Respiratory & Earache

Finding	Pattern
Cough, wheezing, earache	Invasion of Wind attacking the Lungs
Chronic cough, wheezing, sticky sputum	Damp-Phlegm in the Lungs
Skin rash, insomnia, change in character	Latent Heat
Chronic earache	Damp-Heat in the Gall Bladder channel

Sleep & Immunizations

Finding	Pattern
Disturbed sleep with crying, in babies	Retention of food, or Stomach-Heat
Disturbed sleep, older children	Liver-Fire, or Stomach-Heat

Immunization history is also part of the children's intake — noted for the record but no specific pattern correlations were given in lecture.